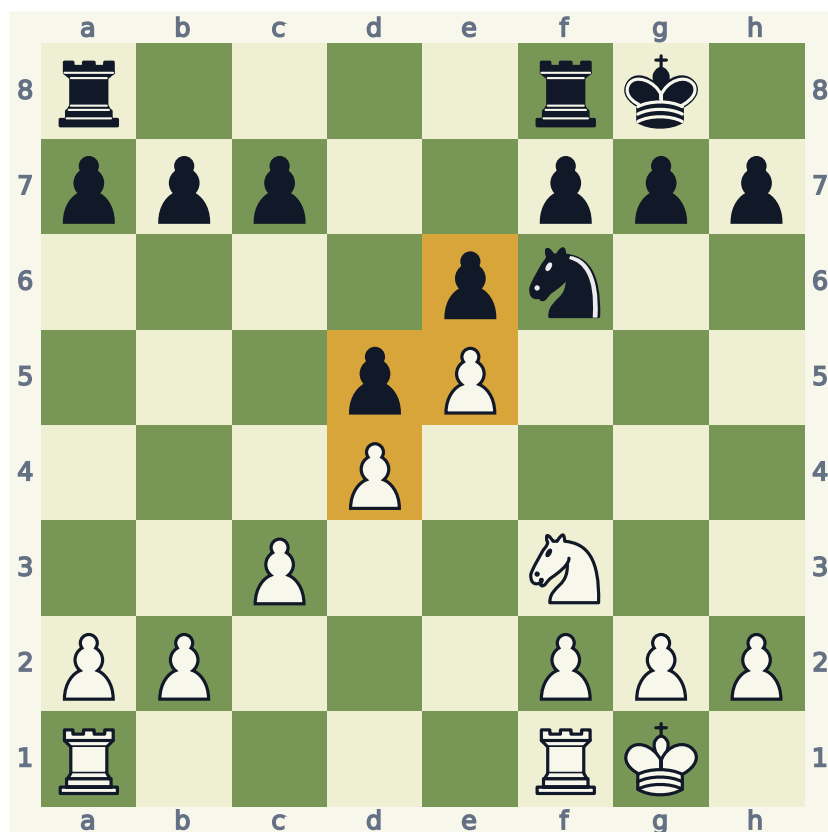


Read the center

The center tells you how much time you have.

An open center favors rapid activity and king safety. A locked center often allows slower maneuvers and play on a flank. A mobile center can advance or be attacked. These are descriptions of current possibilities, not permanent labels: one pawn exchange can change the right plan.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- d4 and d5 lock one central file.
- e5 attacks Nf6 right now: a tactical fact comes first.
- Capturing on f6 changes structure and material; the center label alone cannot decide a move.

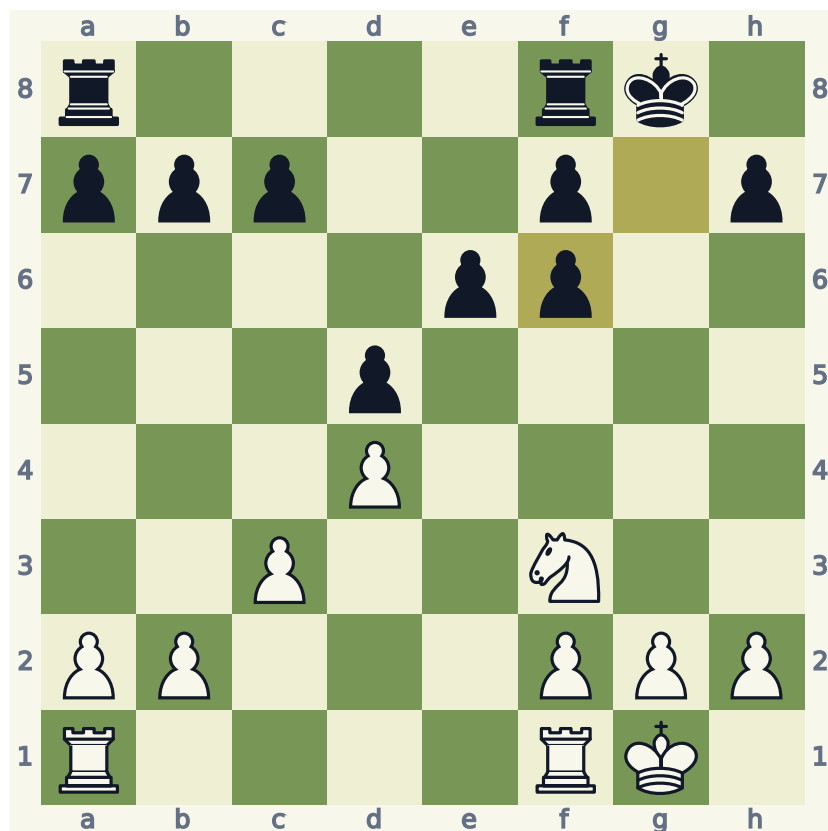
REMEMBER

- Describe the actual pawn contacts.
- Identify the break that changes the center.
- Check forcing moves before classifying.

Follow the logic

1. exf6 gxf6

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



exf6

The pawn captures an attacked knight. Do not ignore available material just because you planned a quiet maneuver.

...gxf6

Black recaptures, creating doubled f-pawns and opening the g-file. White has traded a pawn for a knight.

Reassess

The d-file remains locked, but king safety and material have changed. The next plan should protect the extra piece and meet rook activity.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

With a locked center Black may seek ...c5, attacking d4. The newly opened g-file may also give the rook a useful route. Being structurally worse does not mean having no active resources.

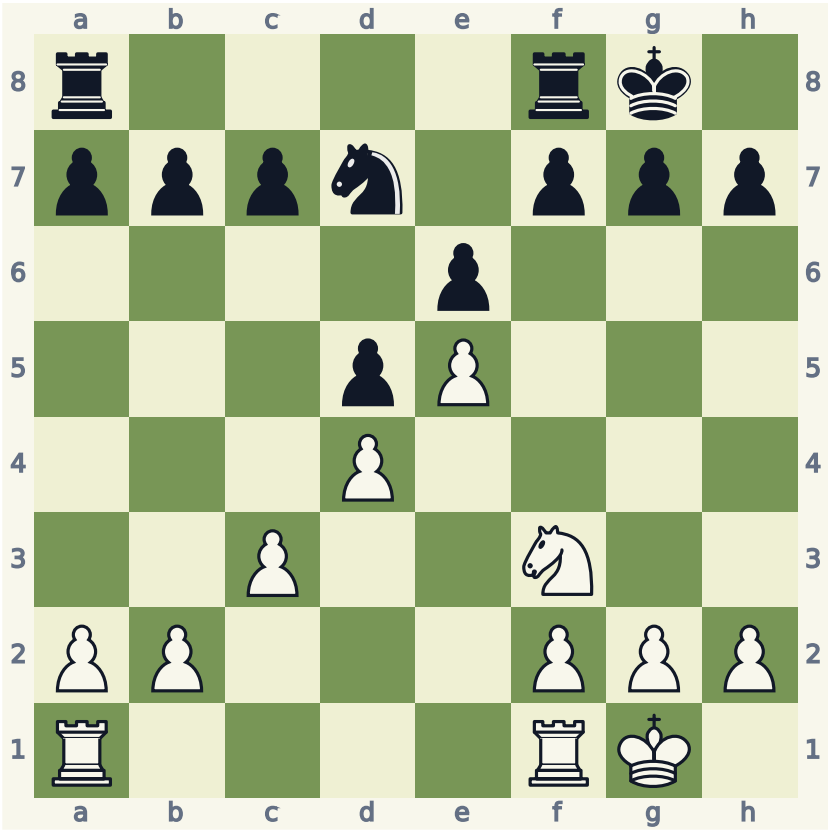
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

This first diagram deliberately includes an immediate capture. A positional concept never excuses overlooking a hanging piece. Also, a closed center can open quickly if a pawn break is ready.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Describe the central locks and White's space.
- 2. Why is ...c5 a logical black break?
- 3. After ...c5, what must White compare before choosing a flank move?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If both pairs of central pawns disappeared, would the same slow flank maneuver remain attractive?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): r4rk1/pppn1ppp/4p3/3pP3/3P4/2P2N2/PP3PPP/R4RK1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. White's d4-pawn is blocked by d5 and e5 is blocked by e6. White has more kingside space. Nf3 is safe, while Black's knight is on d7 rather than the attacked f6-square from the model.
2. ...c5 attacks d4, the base supporting e5. Capturing or exchanging that base can reduce White's space and open the c- or d-file. A flank pawn can therefore change a central structure.
3. Compare maintaining the tension, capturing on c5 and allowing ...cxd4. Check who recaptures and whether e5 remains secure. Rfe1 was a useful developing move, but it does not remove the need to answer the new contact.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Rfe1 c5

Changed feature: It might lose time. With open central files, rook activity and king exposure become more urgent. Count tempi again rather than carrying over the old plan.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Label five positions open, locked or mobile. For each, name one legal pawn exchange that would change the label.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 04, 05, 14. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.